Geographic Differences in Youtube Search Results

Does location affect rates of misinformation exposure?

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CSCE 676 Data Mining Project

Do we all see the same results on Youtube?

Or does location change what you're shown?

Motivation

- Youtube is a major source of information for people
- Search results affect what videos a person is shown
- Videos can be misleading and spread misinformation
- Exposure to misinformation can vary based on the videos a person watches

Image from https://now.tufts.edu/2024/02/23/how-misinformation-and-disinformation-spread-role-ai-and-how-we-can-guard-against-them

Primary Research Question

Does geographic location influence Youtube search results, and affect exposure rates to misinformation?

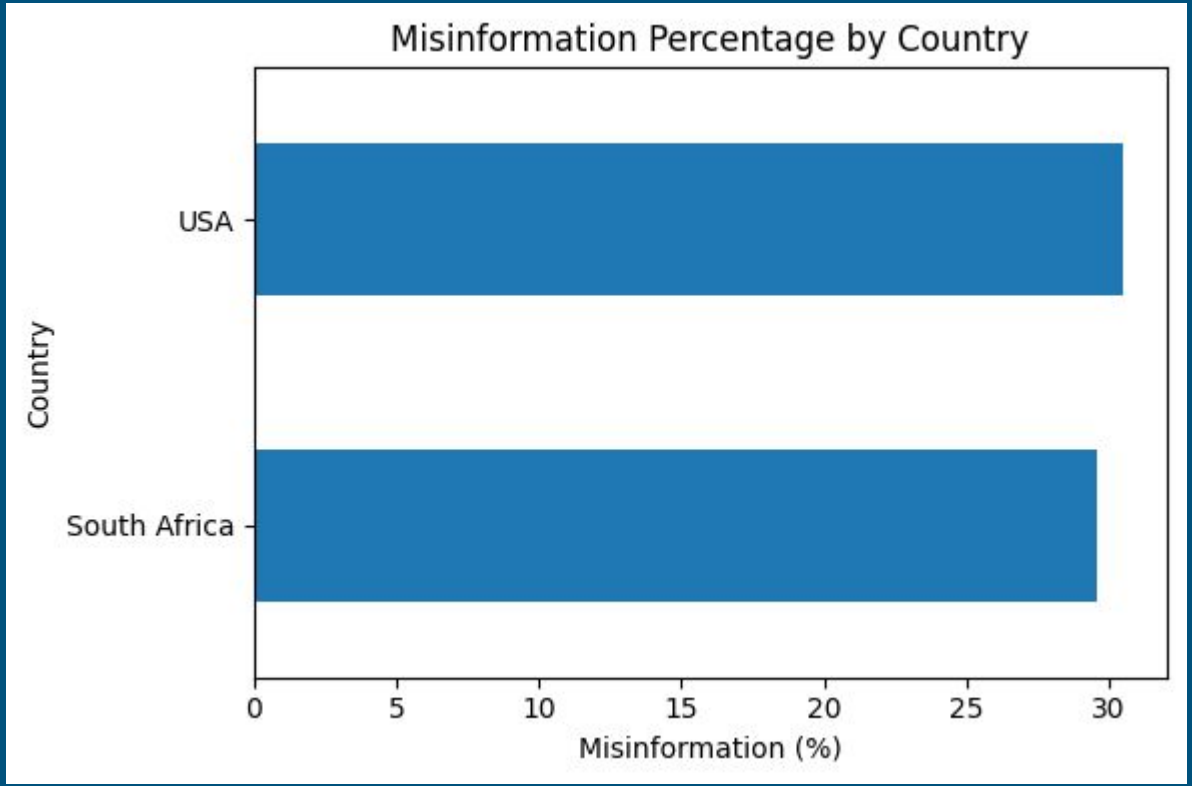
Method

- YouTube audit dataset comparing COVID-19 search results in the US and South Africa
- Same queries, multiple runs
- Analyzed patterns of channels
- Compared misinformation levels

Image from https://medium.com/m/global-identity-2?redirectUrl=https%3A%2F%2Fmedium.muz.li%2Ffeature-breakdown-3-youtube-search-query-web-25c6d318f6d

Key Findings

- Results differ across countries
- Different channels appear in search results for the same query
- Misinformation rates vary based on location
- Filtering methods can affect the spread of misinformation



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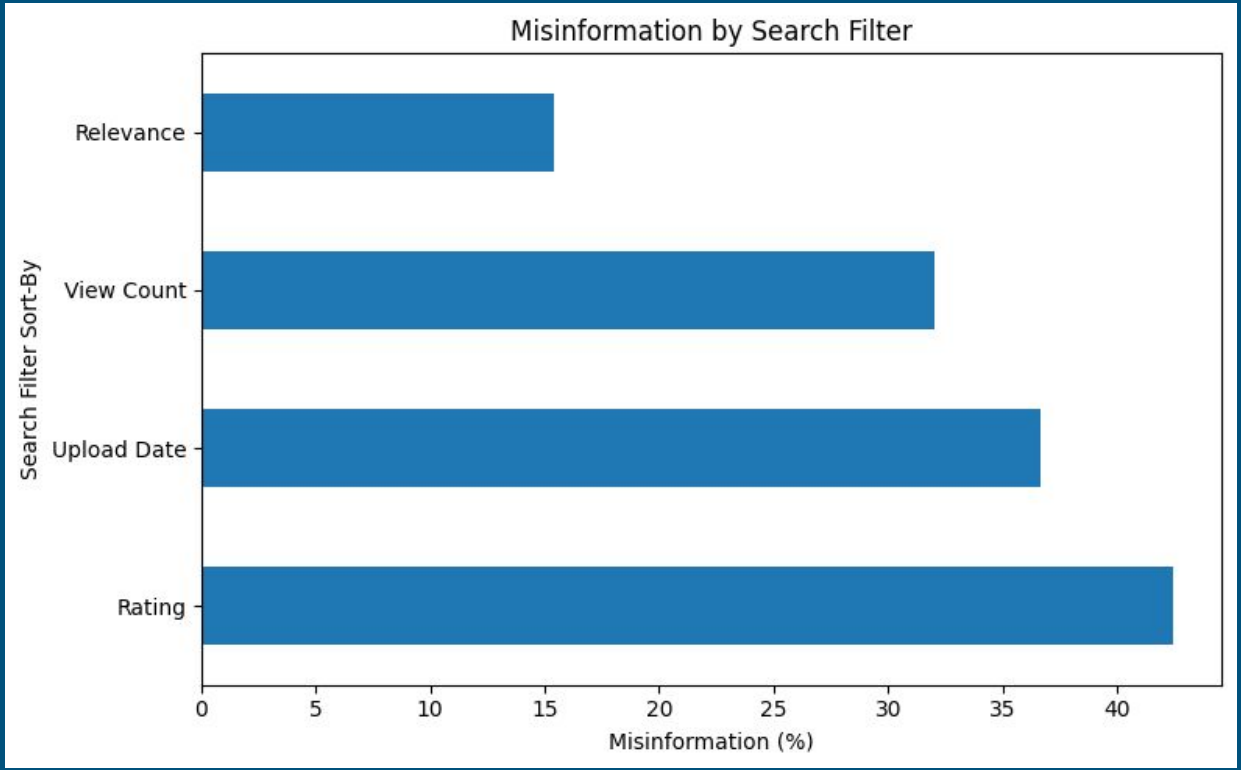

Key Takeaway

- YouTube does NOT show the same information to all users with the same query
- Geographic location and filtering affect what users see and their exposure rate to misinformation

Check out the full project on GitHub:
https://github.com/j-salguero/CSCE676-DataMiningProject